was not going to be enough.

As the year wore on, it began to feel as if I was reaching a crossroads in my cricket career, as if there was a high road and a low road stretching ahead of me. It was time to choose.

In the world of international cricket, time is a precious commodity. Usually, there is no time to plan and to reflect, no time to make changes in technique and no time to create new structures. The calendar is packed and there is rarely any significant amount of time between the end of one series and the start of the next.

We returned home from the 2007 ICC Cricket World Cup in the Caribbean and had to endure both the expected criticism and the usual claims that, in losing so heavily to Australia in the semifinal, we had once again choked on the big occasion. Being beaten by a stronger side never seems an adequate explanation.

There followed two of the more obscure events in the schedule.

The Afro-Asian Cup involved composite teams from Asia and Africa playing three 50-over matches in India, a concept that may have seemed reasonable on paper but generally failed to set any pulses racing. Eight South Africans combined with three Kenyans in the African XI, and we lost the series 3–0. My inconsistent form continued. I was bowled by Mohammad Asif (him again) in the first game, and scored 70 in the third match.

The next stop was Belfast, where South Africa joined hosts Ireland and India in a triangular one-day tournament known as the Future Cup. As it turned out, the Future Cup did not have much of a future, even though there was some decent cricket played and a strong Indian side deservedly claimed the title.

I continued to struggle with the bat and, during the fortnight in Northern Ireland, leaned heavily on the generous support and knowledge of Jacques Kallis as I finally started to address the issue of my defensive technique. In the past, I had struggled but then scored runs